KEY PLAYERS IN THE NEW CABINET



Yogi Adityanath Key departments: home, revenue, personnel, vigilance, a total of 34 departments



Dy CM Keshav Prasad Maurya Rural development, food processing, public enterprises and national integration



Deputy CM Brajesh Pathak Health, family welfare and child welfare



Suresh Khanna Nine-time MLA gets finance and parliamentary affairs



Swatantra Dev Singh Water resources and irrigation dept (Jal Shakti)



Baby Rani Maurya Women's welfare and child nutrition



Arvind Kumar Sharma Urban development and power



Jitin Prasada Public works dept (PWD)

Surya Pratap Shahi Agriculture

Laxmi Narayan Chaudhary Sugarcane development and sugar mills

Nand Gopal 'Nandi' Industrial development and exports

THOSE WHO WERE DROPPED...

Deputy CM **Dinesh Sharma**

Former ministers **Satish Mahana, Siddharth Nath Singh, Jai Pratap Singh, Neelkanth Tiwari, Jai Prakash Nishad** and **Jai Kumar Singh**

Three-time MLA **Ashutosh Tandon**, son of veteran leader late Lalji Tandon

Shrikant Sharma, two-time MLA from Mathura and spokesperson for the UP government till 2022

Neelkanth Tiwari, second-time MLA from Varanasi South, the constituency that houses the Kashi Vishwanath Corridor

around a Brahmin-Thakur conflict this time—there is indeed a touch of caution on that point.

Brahmins are not the only sector to be mollified in UP. The caste breakup of the 52 ministers presents an eclectic picture: 21 from elite castes, 20 OBCs, eight Dalits, one ST, one Sunni Muslim, and one Sikh. Out of that first 21, seven are Brahmins, six Thakurs, two Bhumihars, five Vaishyas, and one Kayastha. Among the OBCs, there are four Kurmis, three Jats, two Nishads, two Lodhs and one each from the Maurya, Gaderia, Saini, Gujjar, Teli, Rajbhar, Yadav, Kumhar, and Kashyap sub-castes. The 20 OBC faces roughly come close to their 40-42 per cent share in the population. And these include OBC leaders from allies, like Ashish Patel (Apna Dal) and Sanjay Nishad (Nishad Party). Anil Rajbhar was also included as cabinet minister—as a face from a community that was seen as wavering in its loyalty, especially after Om Prakash Rajbhar of the Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP) invested on the other side. The Rajbhars are an important OBC community in eastern UP, altering the equations in at least 70 seats. And continuing support from the non-Yadav OBCs was considered a key reason for the BJP's victory. That had to be harnessed.

Dalits are the other constituency that has to be stitched up, even if Mayawati's BSP has been virtually neutralised. A total of eight Dalits were sworn in as ministers in Yogi's cabinet. Baby Rani Maurya and Asim Arun are the two important faces there. A Jatav face, who has already served as the Uttarakhand governor, Baby Rani won from Agra Rural. And Asim Arun, another Jatav and former police commissioner of Kanpur, joined the BJP after taking VRS just before the polls. He won from Kannauj's Sadar seat, considered a Samajwadi Party bastion. Jatav Dalits form 12 per cent of UP's total population, so these are important inclusions.

Among the 31 new faces, there are also surprises. The entry of Congress turncoat Rakesh Sachan, as also Dinesh Singh as an MoS (independent), were among those—a party source attributed these to the "high command". Names like Mahendra Singh and Dinesh Sharma, considered close to Yogi, have been dropped.

Says Rakesh Tripathi, state party spokesperson: "In the BJP, the role of leaders is decided by the organisation. The party can give any role to anyone on the basis of performance. You will notice both *yuva josh* (youthful energy) and experience in the new council of ministers." ■

